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Emotional Intelligence

Steer your emotions and stay on track: a free quick start

FREE QUICK START

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FREE QUICK START

Start here

This is the free quick start of Emotional Intelligence. It covers what EI is, the trigger to action loop, the evidence ranked toolbox, urges and emotional eating, and when to get professional help. The complete guide adds ADHD and emotions, relationships, conflict and worksheets.

The complete guide

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CHAPTER 1

What emotional intelligence is, and is not

A working definition

The most cited scientific model, from Mayer, Salovey and Caruso, treats EI as a set of **abilities**: perceiving emotions in yourself and others, using emotions to support thinking, understanding how emotions work and change, and managing emotions in yourself and in relationships.[1] In plain language, those four abilities are:

Ability	In plain language	Example
Perceive	Notice what you and others feel	"My chest is tight. I am anxious."
Use	Let the emotion inform your thinking	"I feel uneasy about this deal. What is it pointing at?"
Understand	Know where it came from and where it tends to go	"When I feel criticized, I withdraw for two days."
Manage	Choose your response, not just react	"I will answer tomorrow, after I sleep."

What the research does and does not show

You may have read that EI matters more than IQ, or that it accounts for most of success. That claim is not supported. Meta-analyses find that EI measures relate **modestly** to job performance, and researchers disagree about how much they add beyond personality and general intelligence. One large meta-analysis concluded that much of the apparent benefit of some self-report EI measures overlaps with personality traits, and that the link to job performance depends on how much emotional work the job requires.[2] Another found that EI still explained some additional variance in performance beyond personality and intelligence.[3]

> **The honest summary**
>
> EI is a useful skill set, not a superpower. The reason to build it is practical: people who can name and handle their emotions tend to have an easier time with relationships and with sticking to hard plans. The size of the benefit is moderate, and it will not replace sleep, training, good food or professional help.

What EI is not

- **It is not being nice.** You can be very emotionally skilled and still say a hard thing clearly.
- **It is not suppressing feelings.** Pushing emotions down is one of the strategies with weaker results (more on this below).
- **It is not a personality type.** Skills improve with practice. Your starting point matters less than your reps.
- **It is not a test score.** Online quizzes are fun but do not tell you what to practice. Your own log gives you better data.

CHAPTER 2

The loop: trigger, feeling, urge, action

Almost every emotional moment follows the same sequence. Once you see it, you can interrupt it.

1. **Trigger.** Something happens. A text, a comment, a scale number, a quiet evening.
2. **Interpretation.** You tell yourself what it means. "They think I am a failure."
3. **Feeling.** Your body and mind respond. Heat, tightness, sinking, restlessness.
4. **Urge.** You feel pulled toward an action. Eat, drink, scroll, snap, quit, hide.

5. **Action.** You do, or do not do, what the urge says.

The gap you are trying to build is between **urge and action.** You cannot always stop the trigger or the feeling. You can learn to widen the gap, even by ten seconds, so that you choose rather than react.

Naming the feeling helps

Putting a feeling into words is called **affect labeling.** In a brain imaging study, naming the emotion in a face reduced amygdala activity (a region involved in threat responses) and increased activity in a prefrontal region linked to regulation, compared with simply matching the faces.[4] Later reviews describe labeling as a form of implicit emotion regulation, with effects that are real but modest and that vary by person and situation.[5] It is not a cure. It is a cheap first move that costs nothing and can be done in a few seconds.

Be specific: the more precise the word, the better

"I feel bad" gives you one option. "I feel embarrassed" and "I feel lonely" point at different needs. Researchers call this skill **emotion differentiation.** People who describe their emotions with more precision tend to manage them with fewer harmful behaviors such as heavy drinking when upset, though most of this evidence is correlational.[6] Use the table below as a starting vocabulary.

If you say…	Try asking if it is…
"Stressed"	Overwhelmed, pressured, rushed, afraid of failing, afraid of letting someone down
"Angry"	Disrespected, blocked, treated unfairly, hurt (anger often covers hurt)
"Sad"	Disappointed, lonely, grieving, discouraged, tired
"Anxious"	Uncertain, worried about a specific outcome, on edge, unprepared
"Bored"	Under-stimulated, avoiding something, restless, in need of a break
"Guilty" or "ashamed"	Guilty: "I did something bad." Shame: "I am bad." Treat these differently.

The 10-second check-in

Three questions, any time: **What am I feeling (one precise word)? Where do I feel it in my body? What do I feel like doing?** If you can answer those, you have already opened the gap.

CHAPTER 3

Self-management: the toolbox, ranked by evidence

Psychologist James Gross describes emotion regulation as a family of strategies that act at different points in the emotional loop: choosing situations, changing situations, shifting attention, reframing the meaning, and changing the response.[7] They are not equally effective. Here is what the research supports, in plain terms.

Reframing and distraction work; pure suppression is weaker

A meta-analysis of 306 experimental comparisons found that **cognitive reappraisal** (reinterpreting the situation) had a small to moderate effect on emotional outcomes (d = 0.36). **Distraction** was similar (d = 0.27). **Expressive suppression** (hiding the outward signs of an emotion) had a small effect (d = 0.32) on outward expression, but did not reduce how much people actually felt.[8] In a related set of studies, people who habitually reappraised reported better well-being and relationships, while people who habitually suppressed reported more negative outcomes.[9]

Tool	What it is	Evidence strength	Best used when
Reappraisal	Find another honest reading of the situation	Small to moderate effect	Before or early in a feeling, when you have some thinking room
Distraction	Move attention elsewhere on purpose	Small effect; short-term	Intense moments you cannot solve right now
Slow breathing	Long exhale, around 6 breaths per minute	Small effect on calm and arousal	Anytime, especially before a hard talk

Self-distancing	Talk to yourself in the third person or from a future viewpoint	Moderate in lab studies	Rumination, stress before a challenge
Mindfulness practice	Regular practice of noticing without reacting	Small to moderate for anxiety and low mood	Daily, as a base skill
Suppression	Push the feeling down and hide it	Does not reduce the feeling	Short-term professional moments only

Reappraisal: change the story, not the facts

Reappraisal does not mean pretending. It means asking what else could be true. Not "it is fine" but "what is another honest way to read this?"

Automatic thought	Reappraised thought
"I ate badly, the week is ruined."	"One meal is one meal. My average is what counts. Next meal is the next vote."
"They did not reply, they are annoyed with me."	"They may be busy. I can ask, or wait until tomorrow."
"I missed my workout. I always quit."	"I missed one. The plan assumes some misses. What is the 10-minute version?"
"I have no willpower."	"I have a hard situation and not enough support in it. What can I change in the setup?"

Slow breathing: a small, fast tool

A systematic review of slow breathing techniques reported links with greater relaxation, comfort and alertness and reductions in anxiety, anger and arousal, mostly in small studies.[10] The effect is modest, and not a substitute for treatment, but it is free and quick. Try this: **inhale through the nose for 4 seconds, exhale slowly through the mouth for 6 to 8 seconds, for 2 to 5 minutes.** If it makes you dizzy, slow down or stop.

Self-distancing: talk to yourself like a coach

In a set of experiments, people who reflected on a stressful event using their own name or "you" instead of "I" showed less emotional reactivity and rated themselves as less anxious about an upcoming speech.[11] This is the "What would I tell a friend?" move, with a little more structure.

Try: "Adriano, you are nervous. What do you need right now?" It sounds silly and works for many people.

Mindfulness: slow but useful

A meta-analysis of 47 trials found that mindfulness meditation programs produced **small to moderate** improvements in anxiety and depression, with low evidence for effects on stress and quality of life, and none shown for substance use or weight.[12] It is not magic. It is a skill that pays off with regular practice, five to ten minutes per day.

Pick two tools, not ten

Choose one tool for the moment of the feeling (breathing, or reappraisal) and one for the daily base (mindfulness, or the three-line log). Practice them for a week before you add anything.

CHAPTER 4

Urges, cravings and emotional eating

Emotion drives a lot of eating and drinking

The link between negative emotions and eating is real, though it is not the same for everyone. A review of studies found that **emotional eating** (eating in response to negative emotions) is associated with higher intake of energy-dense foods and with higher body weight, but the strength of the link varies, and some people eat less when stressed.[13] In the alcohol field, a study of people in treatment found that **difficulty tolerating negative emotions** predicted alcohol use during and after treatment.[14] The same skill gap can show up in different behaviors.

An urge is not an order

An urge is a wave. It rises, peaks, and usually falls within minutes if you do not feed it. This idea is the basis of **urge surfing,** a skill taught in mindfulness-based relapse prevention. In a randomized trial of 286 adults after treatment for substance use disorders, those who got mindfulness-based relapse prevention had fewer days of substance use and heavy drinking at 12 months than those who got usual aftercare.[15] It does not work for everyone, and it works best alongside other support, but it shows that you can learn to ride out an urge.

Urge surfing: the five steps

1. **Stop and name it.** "This is an urge to eat/drink/scroll." Not "I need."
2. **Locate it in your body.** Throat, stomach, hands. Describe it like a scientist.
3. **Breathe slowly** while you watch it, 2 to 5 minutes.
4. **Notice it change.** Urges grow, peak and fade. Rate it 0 to 10 every minute.
5. **Choose.** After the wave, decide what to do. You are allowed to still choose the food, but now you choose it.

Emotional eating: three questions before you eat

Question	Why it helps
"Am I physically hungry?"	When did I last eat? Is my stomach asking, or my mind?
"What am I feeling right now?"	Uses affect labeling. Often the answer is tired, lonely, bored or stressed.
"What do I actually need?"	Rest, a call, a walk, a shower, a snack. Sometimes the answer is food. That is fine.

If the answer is "I am hungry," eat. A reliable plan with enough food (see the Nutrition guide) reduces the number of urges that are really hunger. If the answer is "I am stressed" or "I am lonely," the food will not fix that, and a small 10-minute alternative might (walk, shower, text a friend, tea, 5 minutes of breathing).

The pause rule

Before acting on a strong urge, wait **10 minutes** and do something else (walk, water, breathing). This is my coaching rule, not a clinical threshold. Many people find that after the wait, the urge is weaker or gone. If it is still there, you can decide with a clearer head.

Alcohol and recovery

I have been sober for four years, so this topic is personal to me, but I am not a treating clinician. If you drink heavily, do not stop suddenly without medical advice, because alcohol withdrawal can be dangerous. If you want to cut back or stop, talk to a doctor, and consider structured support such as therapy or a mutual-help group. The skills in this guide (naming feelings, urge surfing, planning for triggers) are tools to use alongside that support, not a replacement for it.

CHAPTER 5

When to get professional help

These tools help with ordinary emotional ups and downs. They are not enough on their own when the problem is large. Please talk to a licensed professional if you notice any of the following:

- You feel persistently sad, empty, hopeless or numb for two weeks or more.
- Your anxiety, anger or panic is interfering with work, sleep, relationships or eating.
- You use food, alcohol, drugs, gambling or other behaviors to cope and cannot stop.
- You are binge eating, purging, restricting severely or feel out of control around food.
- You have had a major loss, trauma or abuse and it still overwhelms you.
- You think about harming yourself or ending your life.

If you are in danger or thinking of suicide

In the United States, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline). **In Brazil, call 188** (CVV, free and 24 hours). **Elsewhere, contact your local emergency number.** If you are in immediate danger, call emergency services right away. For help with substance use in the US, SAMHSA's helpline is **1-800-662-4357**, free and confidential. You do not have to be sure you are in crisis to call.

A coach can help you with habits, structure and accountability. A psychologist, psychiatrist or doctor can diagnose and treat. Both can matter, and seeking help is not weakness. It is what a good plan includes.

Want more? The complete guide has every chapter, worksheets and the full reference list. adrianonutrition.com/guides

Questions?

Send me a DM on Instagram: @adriano.nutrition. I read every message.

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